

A STUDY OF THE PARABLES

(Lifegroups)

TEXT: [Matthew 13:1-9](#) (KJV) *“The same day went Jesus out of the house, and sat by the sea side. 2 And great multitudes were gathered together unto him, so that he went into a ship, and sat; and the whole multitude stood on the shore. 3 And he spake many things unto them in parables, saying, **Behold, a sower went forth to sow; 4 And when he sowed, some seeds fell by the way side, and the fowls came and devoured them up: 5 Some fell upon stony places, where they had not much earth: and forthwith they sprung up, because they had no deepness of earth: 6 And when the sun was up, they were scorched; and because they had no root, they withered away. 7 And some fell among thorns; and the thorns sprung up, and choked them: 8 But other fell into good ground, and brought forth fruit, some an hundredfold,***

some sixtyfold, some thirtyfold. 9 Who hath ears to hear, let him hear. “

INTRO: Jesus was the master teacher. In His day He used a variety of visual effects to get His point across. He was a master communicator. He implemented and mastered a technique of teaching by using Parables. The word parable is derived from the Greek verb paraballo, and means to "lay by the side of," to "compare"; something with a "likeness, similitude." (New Unger's Bible Dictionary) In common terms a parable is a common story which points to common things to teach a Kingdom Principle.

Matthew thirteen is almost entirely devoted to a collection of Parables. In this collection of parables there is a common thread which runs through each of them. This thread is the affect of the Word of God on the life of believers. More specifically it comes down

to the rise and fall of Christian faith in the life of a believer.

Faith is predicated, developed and deployed through the Word of God. The basis of faith should never be emotion or experience. A person with little experience can have great faith while a person with great experience can be found to have little faith. All faith is based on the Word of God.

I. THE PARABLE OF THE SOWER...

This collection of Parables begins with a lesson on seed and soil. Look at verses 18-23, (NKJV) ***“Therefore hear the parable of the sower:19 “When anyone hears the word of the kingdom, and does not understand it, then the wicked one comes and snatches away what was sown in his heart. This is he who received seed by the wayside.20 “But he who received the seed on stony places, this is he who hears the word and immediately receives it with***

joy;21 “yet he has no root in himself, but endures only for a while. For when tribulation or persecution arises because of the word, immediately he stumbles.22

“Now he who received seed among the thorns is he who hears the word, and the cares of this world and the deceitfulness of riches choke the word, and he becomes unfruitful.23 “But he who received seed on the good ground is he who hears the word and understands it, who indeed bears fruit and produces: some a hundredfold, some sixty, some thirty.” We are going to discuss three things in this lesson:

- The seed...
- The soil...
- The sower...

THE SEED: Jesus very plainly describes what the seed in [Luke 8:11](#) (NKJV) *“Now the parable is this: The seed is the word of God.”*”

Seeds:

- Are capable of producing life...
- Are capable of generating much more of their kind...
- Are capable of lying dormant and then coming back to life...

The seed of the Word of God is a powerful life giving force but until it is sown it is just a dead book of historical events. Once it is sown and begins to grow, kingdom principles which have heretofore been hidden begin to be extremely apparent.

Notice, every other Parable in the collection after this one begins with the phrase “*The Kingdom of Heaven is like...*” This is because once we get the seed sowing right we can then begin to understand kingdom principles which will help mature us. 1

[Corinthians 1:18-25](#) (NLT) “*I know very well how foolish the message of the cross sounds to those who are on the road to destruction. But we who are being saved recognize this message as the very power of*

God. 19 As the Scriptures say, “I will destroy human wisdom and discard their most brilliant ideas.” 20 So where does this leave the philosophers, the scholars, and the world’s brilliant debaters? God has made them all look foolish and has shown their wisdom to be useless nonsense. 21 Since God in his wisdom saw to it that the world would never find him through human wisdom, he has used our foolish preaching to save all who believe. 22 God’s way seems foolish to the Jews because they want a sign from heaven to prove it is true. And it is foolish to the Greeks because they believe only what agrees with their own wisdom. 23 So when we preach that Christ was crucified, the Jews are offended, and the Gentiles say it’s all nonsense. 24 But to those called by God to salvation, both Jews and Gentiles, Christ is the mighty power of God and the wonderful wisdom of God. 25 This “foolish” plan of God is far wiser than the wisest of human plans, and God’s

weakness is far stronger than the greatest of human strength.”

Have you ever noticed how difficult it is for the unsaved to understand kingdom principles?

- They do not understand how we can forsake sin and improve the enjoyment and quality of our life.
- They do not understand how a person can possess the self determination to say NO to sinful practices.
- They do not understand how you can give your money away (tithing) and actually end up with more.

This is because they have been blinded by the enemy. [2 Corinthians 4:3-4](#) (NKJV)

“But even if our gospel is veiled, it is veiled to those who are perishing,⁴ whose minds the god of this age has blinded, who do not believe, lest the light of the gospel of the

glory of Christ, who is the image of God, should shine on them.”

THE SOIL: Matthew 13:19-23 (NKJV)

“When anyone hears the word of the kingdom, and does not understand it, then the wicked one comes and snatches away what was sown in his heart. This is he who received seed by the wayside.²⁰ “But he who received the seed on stony places, this is he who hears the word and immediately receives it with joy;²¹ “yet he has no root in himself, but endures only for a while. For when tribulation or persecution arises because of the word, immediately he stumbles.²² “Now he who received seed among the thorns is he who hears the word, and the cares of this world and the deceitfulness of riches choke the word, and he becomes unfruitful.²³ “But he who received seed on the good ground is he who hears the word and understands it, who indeed bears fruit and produces: some a

hundredfold, some sixty, some thirty.” The soil is the life of those upon whom the seed of the Word of God has fallen. In this passage of Scripture **Jesus unveils four kinds of soil:**

- **Wayside soil** – The seed is sown in the wrong place. The ground was not ready. The seed was stepped on and the birds made a meal of it!
- **Stony soil** – There is no depth, as a result when difficulty or persecution arises the individual falls away!
- **Thorny soil** – This kind of soil makes an attempt to grow two enemies in the same parcel of ground. Fruit producing seed and thorns are enemies of one another! The cares of life and the deceitfulness of riches are terminal to this soil type. Thorny soil has major problems with success. Success becomes the main thing rather than producing fruit for the kingdom.

- [Good soil](#) – This type of soil is identified by receptivity, application, and production. When we receive the Word of God, make a personal application with it, and produce fruit, the fruit we produce will be the fruit of the Spirit and we will win souls! [Galatians 5:22-23](#) (NKJV) ***“But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, longsuffering, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, self-control. Against such there is no law.”***

Our lives are the soil which Jesus speaks of here and we all fall into one of the four previous categories. Where would you place yourself? [We are responsible for the kind of soil the Word of God falls on in our life!](#) [Hosea 10:12](#) (NKJV) ***“Sow for yourselves righteousness; Reap in mercy; Break up your fallow ground, For it is time to seek the LORD, Till He comes and rains***

righteousness on you.” This is not a sweet little suggestion, it is a commandment!

We have a personal responsibility to come to a good understanding of the Word of God! Solomon said, Proverbs 4:7 (NKJV) *“Wisdom is the principal thing; Therefore get wisdom. And in all your getting, get understanding.”* Paul said to Timothy, 2 Timothy 2:15 (KJV) *“Study to shew thyself approved unto God, a workman that needeth not to be ashamed, rightly dividing the word of truth.”*

THE SOWER: Matthew 13:3 (NKJV)

“Behold, a sower went out to sow.”

In this Scripture the Sower is:

- Jesus – The seed is the Word, the sower is the husbandman or farmer/owner.

John 1:14 (NKJV) *“And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and we beheld His glory, the glory as of the only begotten of the Father, full of*

grace and truth.” He not only became the Word, through His crucifixion and death He made that Word available to all who would receive Him. [John 1:12](#)

(NKJV) *“But as many as received Him, to them He gave the right to become children of God, to those who believe in His name:”*

- [Every believer](#) - Once we have received the truth of the Word of God we have a personal responsibility for evangelism or the distribution of the seed of the Word of God. [Mark 16:15-16](#) (NKJV) *“And He said to them, **Go into all the world and preach the gospel to every creature.16 “He who believes and is baptized will be saved; but he who does not believe will be condemned.”***

Too many seeds are being lost to the enemy; it is time for the church of Jesus to get understanding when it comes to the Word of God.

II. THE PARABLE OF THE WHEAT AND TARES...

Matthew 13:24-30 (NKJV) *“Another parable He put forth to them, saying: **“The kingdom of heaven is like a man who sowed good seed in his field;²⁵ “but while men slept, his enemy came and sowed tares among the wheat and went his way.²⁶ “But when the grain had sprouted and produced a crop, then the tares also appeared.²⁷ “So the servants of the owner came and said to him, ‘Sir, did you not sow good seed in your field? How then does it have tares?’²⁸ “He said to them, ‘An enemy has done this.’ The servants said to him, ‘Do you want us then to go and gather them up?’²⁹ “But he said, ‘No, lest while you gather up the tares you also uproot the wheat with them.³⁰ ‘Let both grow together until the harvest, and at the time of harvest I will say to the reapers, “First gather together the tares and bind them in bundles to burn them, but gather the wheat into my barn.”***

Once again, Jesus makes us aware of the fact, the farmer sowed good seed.

Remember, the ground is our life, our spiritual walk with the Lord as well as our temporal walk.

The problem here is not with the quality of the seed; first and foremost, the seed is good. [What is the seed? The Word of God!](#) [2 Timothy 3:16-17](#) (NKJV) “*All Scripture is given by inspiration of God, and is profitable for doctrine, for reproof, for correction, for instruction in righteousness,17 that the man of God may be complete, thoroughly equipped for every good work.*” The seed is supposed to produce a righteous fruitful life. The Word is designed and assigned to each believer for “*Every good work.*”

If the seed is sown and does not produce such a life, the problem is not in the seed it's a totally different problem.

The problem is what is mixed in the seed which Jesus describes as “*tares.*”

What is a tare? A tare is a foreign enemy of a good thing. This can be false doctrine or people with evil motives.

How do tares gain entrance into our lives?
“While the farmer slept his enemy came in and sowed tares among the wheat and went his way.”

I want to point out two things here:

- Each believer has a responsibility to safeguard his or her life from allowing seed which has been corrupted from being sown into our life. Peter 5:8-9 (NKJV) ***“Be sober , be vigilant; because your adversary the devil walks about like a roaring lion, seeking whom he may devour.”*** We are admonished in Scripture to guard against lethargy. Romans 13:11 (NKJV) ***“And do this, knowing the time, that now it is high***

time to awake out of sleep; for now our salvation is nearer than when we first believed.” 1 Thessalonians 5:5-9

(NKJV) “*You are all sons of light and sons of the day. We are not of the night nor of darkness.6 Therefore let us not sleep, as others do, but let us watch and be sober.7 For those who sleep, sleep at night, and those who get drunk are drunk at night.8 But let us who are of the day be sober, putting on the breastplate of faith and love, and as a helmet the hope of salvation.9 For God did not appoint us to wrath, but to obtain salvation through our Lord Jesus Christ,”*

- Every church leader has a responsibility to safeguard the church against false doctrine and people with wrong motives. Isaiah 62:6 (NKJV) “*I have set watchmen on your walls, O Jerusalem; They shall never hold their peace day or night. You who make mention of the*

***LORD, do not keep silent.” Ezekiel 3:17
(NKJV) “Son of man, I have made you
a watchman for the house of Israel;
therefore hear a word from My mouth,
and give them warning from Me:”***

***Hebrews 13:17 (NKJV) “Obey those
who rule over you, and be submissive,
for they watch out for your souls, as
those who must give account. Let them
do so with joy and not with grief, for
that would be unprofitable for you.”***

The bottom line is, we must be diligent in making sure what we are receiving is good doctrine, lest the enemy send someone to sow tares in our life! Church leaders must be diligent to protect their flocks and do everything in their power to make sure what is being sown in the lives of their people is uncorrupted seed.

We must do three things to keep others from sowing tares in our lives:

- Test the message... 1 John 4:1-3
(NKJV) *“Beloved, do not believe every spirit, but test the spirits, whether they are of God; because many false prophets have gone out into the world.² By this you know the Spirit of God: Every spirit that confesses that Jesus Christ has come in the flesh is of God,³ and every spirit that does not confess that Jesus Christ has come in the flesh is not of God. And this is the spirit of the Antichrist, which you have heard was coming, and is now already in the world.”*
- Test the motive... Matthew 7:15-16
(NKJV) *“Beware of false prophets, who come to you in sheep’s clothing, but inwardly they are ravenous wolves.¹⁶ “You will know them by their fruits. Do men gather grapes from thornbushes or figs from thistles?”*
- Test the walk... Matthew 7:17-20
(NKJV) *“Even so, every good tree bears*

good fruit, but a bad tree bears bad fruit.18 “A good tree cannot bear bad fruit, nor can a bad tree bear good fruit.19 “Every tree that does not bear good fruit is cut down and thrown into the fire.20 “Therefore by their fruits you will know them.”

If you are going to set under my ministry you owe it to yourself and your family to test my message, my motive and my walk. If my ministry has a difficult time passing this threefold test you should run for your life. If the message, motive or walk of another minister has difficulty with this litmus test you should stay as far away from that ministry as possible!

I am amazed at how many people attend a church because of its style! They like the music or the delivery of the preacher! That seems to be the only thing of importance today. Of much greater importance; what is

being said; what the motive is; what does the character of the persons in charge look like?

The enemy is always at work trying to imitate God. He can never be God or overthrow God, so he tries to imitate God. Thus the tare; the tare looks like wheat in its infancy stage of growth; it is hard for the farmer to distinguish between the true wheat and tare so the farmer is forced to let them grow up together until harvest time.

When the wheat and the tares become more mature there are some traits which help distinguish between wheat and tares:

- As wheat begins to mature, it slowly begins to bow over due to the weight of the fruit in its stalk. True believers will live in humility; they don't get puffed up when they are fruitful. They are aware of the same thing David called to Israel's memory in Psalm 124:2-4 (NLT) ***"If the LORD had not been on our side when***

people rose up against us, 3 they would have swallowed us alive because of their burning anger against us. 4 The waters would have engulfed us; a torrent would have overwhelmed us.”

- Tares stand straight up and will not bow at all. A person who operates in this spirit lacks genuine humility. **Proverbs 16:18** (NKJV) “***Pride goes before destruction, And a haughty spirit before a fall.***” Pride demands its way no matter who it affects!
- Wheat kernels are big, thick, fat and full of nutrients. Good kernels of wheat make excellent food. **Galatians 5:22-23** (NKJV) “***But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, longsuffering, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, 23 gentleness, self-control. Against such there is no law.***”
- Tare kernels are very small and are extremely worthless. (You cannot fake

the genuine fruit of the Spirit for very long)

- Wheat kernels have a wholesome taste.
- Tare kernels are bitter in taste.
- Wheat kernels furnish the body with the nutrients it needs to sustain life.
- Tare kernels are toxic and cause all who eat it to become dizzy and disoriented, even the birds that eat it begin to have such reactions.

Having outlined all the differences between wheat kernels and tare kernels, perhaps the most devastating aspect of the tare is the fact that the root system will grow down into the soil and intentionally wrap its root system around the root system of the wheat and if the farmer pulls the tare while in the field he will kill the wheat plant as well. [Matthew 13:24-30](#) (NKJV) *“Another parable He put forth to them, saying: **“The kingdom of heaven is like a man who sowed good seed in his field;25 “but while men slept, his***

enemy came and sowed tares among the wheat and went his way.²⁶ “But when the grain had sprouted and produced a crop, then the tares also appeared.²⁷ “So the servants of the owner came and said to him, ‘Sir, did you not sow good seed in your field? How then does it have tares?’²⁸ “He said to them, ‘An enemy has done this.’ The servants said to him, ‘Do you want us then to go and gather them up?’²⁹ “But he said, ‘No, lest while you gather up the tares you also uproot the wheat with them.’³⁰ ‘Let both grow together until the harvest, and at the time of harvest I will say to the reapers, “First gather together the tares and bind them in bundles to burn them, but gather the wheat into my barn.”

Every person in this room is human! Every human is pronged to mistakes. As individual believers there are times when we are weak and the enemy sows some devastating things into our lives. While we should resist the

enemy, God has an appointed time to separate some things within us!

As a spiritual leader I have certainly made my share of mistakes along the way. The enemy takes every opportunity to sow tares among the wheat. The work of the spiritual leader is to tend the crop and ready it for harvest time.

At harvest time God will separate the wheat from the tares. If I attempt to create this separation some of the wheat will be lost in the process but when God chooses to do it he will rid the field of tares and preserve the wheat for the harvest!

Listen to the explanation of Jesus with regard to the parable of the wheat and the tares: [Matt 13:36-43](#) (NLT) ***“Then, leaving the crowds outside, Jesus went into the house. His disciples said, “Please explain the story of the weeds in the field.” 37 “All***

right," he said. "I, the Son of Man, am the farmer who plants the good seed. 38 The field is the world, and the good seed represents the people of the Kingdom. The weeds are the people who belong to the evil one. 39 The enemy who planted the weeds among the wheat is the Devil. The harvest is the end of the world, and the harvesters are the angels. 40 "Just as the weeds are separated out and burned, so it will be at the end of the world. 41 I, the Son of Man, will send my angels, and they will remove from my Kingdom everything that causes sin and all who do evil, 42 and they will throw them into the furnace and burn them. There will be weeping and gnashing of teeth. 43 Then the godly will shine like the sun in their Father's Kingdom. Anyone who is willing to hear should listen and understand!"

It is imperative that we are found fruitful when the Lord returns.

Equally crucial is that we understand these final thoughts:

- We will always have hypocrites among us.
- It is God's responsibility to deal with tares, we are not to go on a tare finding mission, and if we do, we will become critical of people and destroy good people.
- We must remain true to the Lord and our calling without allowing a critical or religious spirit take us over.

III. THE PARABLE OF THE MUSTARD SEED...

Matt 13:31-32 (NKJV) *“Another parable He put forth to them, saying: "The kingdom of heaven is like a mustard seed, which a man took and sowed in his field, 32 which indeed is the least of all the seeds; but when it is grown it is greater than the*

herbs and becomes a tree, so that the birds of the air come and nest in its branches."

Jesus was truly the Master teacher; He was the greatest communicator who ever lived. He used a host of visual aids in communicating His message, He used:

- A fishing boat...
- A little boy's lunch...
- An alabaster box of ointment...
- A rock...
- The vine and the branches...
- A whip while dealing with the money changers...
- A coin in a fishes' mouth...
- A fig tree...

Jesus just had a knack for using practical things to teach real life lessons concerning Kingdom principles.

All but the first of the parables speak of the Kingdom of Heaven, saying “*The Kingdom of Heaven is like...*” In this lesson I want to draw your attention to what is meant by this phrase:

- The Kingdom of Heaven is in the present tense. From the time of the resurrection of Jesus from the dead, His kingdom has been established in the hearts of men!
- The Kingdom of Heaven is in the future tense. If we follow Christ we will live forever in His future Kingdom!

These two components of the Kingdom of Heaven must be clearly understood by the student in order to come to a clear understanding of the parable of the mustard seed. This parable has everything to do with the impact of the Kingdom of Heaven upon our lives both now and in a much broader eternal sense.

The kingdom of God in the present tense is when Christ is allowed to set up a system of government in the life of an individual to the point of that person making Jesus Lord of their life. [1 Corinthians 6:19-20](#) (NKJV)

“Do you not know that your body is the temple of the Holy Spirit who is in you, whom you have from God, and you are not your own?20 For you were bought at a price; therefore glorify God in your body and in your spirit, which are God’s.”

[If I make Him Lord of my life all my decisions must be filtered through the clearing house of the will of God!](#) He is in control; I am just following His leadership!

[Galatians 2:20](#) (NKJV) ***“I have been crucified with Christ; it is no longer I who live, but Christ lives in me; and the life which I now live in the flesh I live by faith in the Son of God, who loved me and gave Himself for me.”***

Franklin D. Roosevelt said, *“There are no hyphenated Americans, there are only*

Americans.” In other words, you are either an American or you are not an American! So it is with the Kingdom of God, there are no Hyphenated Christians, just Christians.

The mustard seed:

- Is one of the smallest seeds known to man...
- Is not a hybrid plant which means it cannot be mixed with anything else...
- Grows into a huge plant when compared to the size of the seed...

Jesus used the parable of the mustard seed to address two different issues.

- 1) The impact of a Christian full of faith...
- 2) The impact of the corporate church which is living by faith and walking in a supernatural order of ministry...

1) The impact of the Christian full of faith.

Like the mustard seed, faith begins small.

Each of us initially has exactly the same

amount of faith! Romans 12:3 (KJV) “...
God hath dealt to every man the measure of

faith.”

What we do with that faith will determine whether or not it grows. In this parable Jesus indicates that our faith should be ever

increasing! Matthew 13:32 (NKJV) “*When it is grown it is greater than the herbs and becomes a tree...*”

How do we grow our faith?

- By reading and understanding the Word! Romans 10:17 (NKJV) “*So then faith comes by hearing, and hearing by the word of God.”*
- By exercising our faith, or putting the Word into practice! James 2:17-18 (NKJV) “*Thus also faith by itself, if it does not have works, is dead.18 But someone will say, “You have faith, and I have works.” Show me your faith*

without your works, and I will show you my faith by my works.” A

demonstration of faith is to the spirit what exercise is to the physical body; if we desire to be strong and in good physical condition, we must develop a consistent exercise routine which allows the body to become toned. If we want to become mighty for God we must exercise our faith on a regular basis!

In this parable, Jesus takes this train of thought one step further; He say's [Matthew 13:32](#) (NKJV) **“When it is grown it is greater than the herbs and becomes a tree, so that the birds of the air come and nest in its branches.”**

Jesus is making a very confident statement regarding the usefulness of our faith when it is full grown. The inference here is that we should regularly listen to the Word of God and exercise our faith until our faith is useful for more than a personal application!

Our faith is given to us to aid us in our personal walk with the Lord but his desire is to use our faith to bless others. Our faith is to become so great that others will seek us out in their times of distress!

2) The impact of the corporate church which is living by faith and walking in a supernatural order of ministry...

The modern church has been neutered by short sighted sensual living! We have been conditioned to live by our senses rather than walking by faith! We hear phrases like:

- What's in it for me?
- This is how I feel...
- I like...
- I don't like...

The Word tells us this kind of living will get us into trouble and cannot please God!

Hebrews 11:6 (NKJV) “*But without faith it is impossible to please Him, for he who comes to God must believe that He is, and*”

that He is a rewarder of those who diligently seek Him.”

On a greater scale I believe Jesus is saying that He would plant His Church and though its beginning would be small, yet its impact would be great! Matthew 16:13-19 (KJV)

*“When Jesus came into the coasts of Caesarea Philippi, he asked his disciples, saying, **Whom do men say that I the Son of man am?** 14 And they said, Some say that thou art John the Baptist: some, Elias; and others, Jeremias, or one of the prophets. 15 He saith unto them, **But whom say ye that I am?** 16 And Simon Peter answered and said, Thou art the Christ, the Son of the living God. 17 And Jesus answered and said unto him, **Blessed art thou, Simon Barjona: for flesh and blood hath not revealed it unto thee, but my Father which is in heaven. 18 And I say also unto thee, That thou art Peter, and upon this rock I will build my church; and the gates of hell shall not prevail against it.***

19 And I will give unto thee the keys of the kingdom of heaven: and whatsoever thou shalt bind on earth shall be bound in heaven: and whatsoever thou shalt loose on earth shall be loosed in heaven.”

In Acts two the church was born and over the centuries it has grown and promoted generations of people to the Heavenly Kingdom. From its meager beginning of 120 in an upper room the church has grown to a point where it is completely possible to fulfill the great commission! According to “*Missions Frontiers*” the following statistics will show the impact the church is having:

It took 1430 years for Bible-believing Christians to become just one percent of world population.

- By AD **1430**, (1%) were Bible believing Christians. (One to 99 after 1430 years)
- By AD **1790**, (2%) were Bible believing Christians. (One to 49 after 360 years)

- By AD 1940, (3%) were Bible believing Christians. (One to 32 after 150 years)
- By AD 1960, (4%) were Bible believing Christians. (One to 24 after 20 years)
- By AD 1970, (5%) were Bible believing Christians. (One to 19 after 10 years)
- By AD 1980, (6%) were Bible believing Christians. (One to 16 after 10 years)
- By AD 1983, (7%) were Bible believing Christians. (One to 13 after 3 years)
- By AD 1986, (8%) were Bible believing Christians. (One to 11 after 3 years)
- By AD 1989, (9%) were Bible believing Christians. (One to 10 after 3 years)
- By AD 1993, (10%) were Bible believing Christians. (One to 9 after 4 years)
- By AD 1997, (11%) were Bible believing Christians. (One to 8 after 4 years)

Overall World Population is growing by 1.6% each year:

- Pentecostals and Charismatics are growing by 7.3% annually.
- Evangelicals are growing by 5.7% annually.
- Protestants are growing by 2.9% annually.
- Catholics are growing by 1.2% annually.
- All other Christians are growing by 2.6% annually.
- Muslims are growing by 2.7% annually.

Patrick Johnstone said, *“Evangelical Christians are the fastest growing major religious group in the world today and it is the only one growing rapidly by conversion.”*

Think of this, from a meeting consisting of three hundred participants in Hot springs, Arkansas in 1914, the Assemblies of God has grown to almost 54,000,000 worldwide! In the parable of the mustard seed, Jesus is saying, if the church becomes what it is

supposed to be; a people of faith and people of the Spirit; the world would flock to it in an effort to make sense of their personal problems!

I want us to be people of faith and the Spirit!

IV. THE PARABLE OF THE LEAVEN...

Matthew 13: 33 (NKJV) “*Another parable He spoke to them: ‘The kingdom of heaven is like leaven, which a woman took and hid in three measures of meal till it was all leavened.’”*

This parable is quite short and does not give us very many details upon which to build a lesson. I assume that the contents of this parable were so common in Jesus’ day that not much explanation was needed to inform the hearer of its meaning. In modern times a little more detail would be required to help us to understand its deeper spiritual meaning.

In most instances throughout Scripture leaven is spoken of in the context of sin. It is quite obvious the kingdom of heaven is not like sin so what could this parable be saying to us?

Leaven is what we would call yeast. The definition for yeast is *“A living organism used in the production of bread and beer. Yeast, in the environment of sugar, produces carbon dioxide and alcohol. This process is called fermentation. Bread yeast comes in dry granulated and fresh cakes. A new form of yeast, called instant yeast, has been developed which allows the user to mix the yeast directly into the flour without dissolving it first in water.”*

In the culinary world proper amounts of yeast are required in baking bread and other pastries which produce a delicious and

optically pleasing product. Leaven does several things:

- Leaven changes the quality, not the substance of the dough. It is still dough, yet it is changed. When we receive the Gospel we are no less a person yet we are changed. [2 Corinthians 5:17](#) (NKJV) ***“Therefore, if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation; old things have passed away; behold, all things have become new.”*** [Ephesians 4:21-24](#) (NKJV) ***“If indeed you have heard Him and have been taught by Him, as the truth is in Jesus:22 that you put off, concerning your former conduct, the old man*** ***which grows corrupt according to the deceitful lusts,23 and be renewed in the spirit of your mind,24 and that you put on the new man*** ***which was created according to God, in true righteousness and holiness.”*** [Colossians 3:9-10](#) (NKJV) ***“Do not lie to one another, since you have put off the old man with***

his deeds,10 and have put on the new man who is renewed in knowledge according to the image of Him who created him.”

- **Leaven makes the bread soft, no longer hard.** The leaven of the Gospel does the very same thing; it penetrates the hardness of a person’s heart and makes the heart soft and pliable. The heart then becomes tenderer toward the Lord and the needs of others. The individual becomes a more caring and giving person. A soft heart is one of the trademarks of a transformed individual.
- **Leaven makes bread porous and moist.** The Gospel has the same effect; it penetrates the dryness and deadness of a person’s heart and creates pores which can hold the moisture of the Word, allowing a climate for the Word to grow into its intended product.
- **Leaven makes bread satisfying, no longer unfulfilling.** The leaven of the

Gospel transforms the life of an individual who is living a life which is dissatisfied, purposeless, without meaning, or significance. The Gospel brings joy, hope, purpose and peace.

- **Leaven makes bread nourishing, no longer of little or no benefit.** The person who receives the Gospel finds fulfillment for unfulfilled dreams. The Gospel fills any void an individual can experience.
- **Leaven works slowly and gradually, yet consistently.** It takes time for the leaven to complete its work. The work of the Word is a process in the life of the believer. **1 Peter 2:2-3 (NKJV) “As newborn babes, desire the pure milk of the word, that you may grow thereby,³ if indeed you have tasted that the Lord is gracious.” 2 Peter 3:18 (NKJV) “Grow in the grace and knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ. To**

*Him be the glory both now and forever.
Amen.”*

- [Leaven works quietly](#). The Word does its work in the life of the individual without a lot of fanfare.

[On several occasions a measure of meal is used as an offering to the Lord:](#)

- [Abraham](#) did this in Genesis 18.
- [Gideon](#) brought 3 measures of meal in Judges 6.
- [Hannah](#) brought 3 measures of meal in 1 Samuel.

The meal offering in Leviticus always followed the burnt offering. The burnt offering was required for forgiveness, which was a sign of a man's commitment and devotion to the Lord. The Meal Offering was an offering of hospitality which was symbolic of the relationship between the worshipper and God upon the basis of the worshipper's service. In other words, for

God's word to have God's desired affect in our lives we must cooperate with His Word and purpose in our lives.

In this parable, leaven represents the Gospel. Leaven is normally mixed in unfinished meal. Here the following word picture is being is being painted:

- The Gospel is to be mixed into an unfinished and imperfect person.
- The Gospel is to be mixed into an unfinished and imperfect church in its earthly state!
- The Gospel is to be mixed into an unfinished and imperfect world!

The Gospel cannot do its work unless and until it has been placed INTO the world and the church! We are the purveyors and distributors of that Gospel!

Believers have been assigned the responsibility of mixing the Gospel into the

world and this worlds system. Matthew 28:19-20 (NKJV) **“Go therefore and make disciples of all the nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit,20 “teaching them to observe all things that I have commanded you; and lo, I am with you always, even to the end of the age.”** Titus 2:15 (NKJV) **“Speak these things, exhort, and rebuke with all authority. Let no one despise you.”** 2 Corinthians 4:13 (NKJV) **“And since we have the same spirit of faith, according to what is written, “I believed and therefore I spoke,” we also believe and therefore speak.”** 1 Peter 3:15 (NKJV) **“But sanctify the Lord God in your hearts, and always be ready to give a defense to everyone who asks you a reason for the hope that is in you, with meekness and fear.”**

To use meal alone to make bread is to misuse the meal and misrepresent the bread. When individuals and churches attempt to short circuit the volume of the leaven of the

Gospel in their lives and ministries, they misuse their reason for existing and misrepresent the real intention of the Gospel.

The Gospel is extremely powerful. 1 Corinthians 1:5-6 (NKJV) “You were enriched in everything by Him in all utterance and all knowledge,⁶ even as the testimony of Christ was confirmed in you.”

A little leaven goes a long way! Galatians 5:9 (NKJV) “*A little leaven leavens the whole lump.*” A person who will allow just a little of the Gospel to penetrate his life will discover the Gospel changing his entire life!

Acts 17:11-12 (NKJV) “*These were more fair-minded than those in Thessalonica, in that they received the word with all readiness, and searched the Scriptures daily to find out whether these things were so.*¹² *Therefore many of them believed, and also not a few of the Greeks, prominent women as well as men.*”

V. THE PARABLE OF THE TREASURE...

Matt 13:44 (NKJV) *“Again, the kingdom of heaven is like treasure hidden in a field, which a man found and hid; and for joy over it he goes and sells all that he has and buys that field.”*

The first four parables are to those who see in the present tense. The second set of four parables is primarily to those who see through the eyes of faith. The Kingdom of God and the Word of God must be received and understood by faith. Hebrews 11:6

(NKJV) *“But without faith it is impossible to please Him, for he who comes to God must believe that He is, and that He is a rewarder of those who diligently seek Him.”*

Those who have no faith can neither believe the Word of God nor receive the Kingdom of God. Hebrews 4:1-2 (NKJV) *“Therefore, since a promise remains of entering His*

rest, let us fear lest any of you seem to have come short of it.² For indeed the gospel was preached to us as well as to them; but the word which they heard did not profit them, not being mixed with faith in those who heard it.”

In this second set of four parables Christ seems to be primarily addressing his disciples. These parables go to the level of those who can handle spiritual matters and not all can.

There are two schools of thought which I believe to be plausible with regard to this parable:

1) The man represents Jesus Christ and the field represents potential believers who are in the world. In this scenario Jesus sees the treasure of men in the world, and seeing them he does five things:

- He hides the treasure! He takes the treasure and tucks them away until He can finish the work of redemption. John

10:14-16,27-30 (NKJV) ***"I am the good shepherd; and I know My sheep, and am known by My own.15 "As the Father knows Me, even so I know the Father; and I lay down My life for the sheep.16 "And other sheep I have which are not of this fold; them also I must bring, and they will hear My voice; and there will be one flock and one shepherd.27 "My sheep hear My voice, and I know them, and they follow Me.28 "And I give them eternal life, and they shall never perish; neither shall anyone snatch them out of My hand.29 "My Father, who has given them to Me, is greater than all; and no one is able to snatch them out of My Father's hand.30 "I and My Father are one."***

- **He goes!** When the scripture say's ***"He goes"*** it is suggesting that He left His permanent home to make a trip to the earth to do something about the hidden

treasure! **Luke 19:10** (NKJV) ***“For the Son of Man has come to seek and to save that which was lost.”*** **John 3:16-17** (NKJV) ***“For God so loved the world that He gave His only begotten Son, that whoever believes in Him should not perish but have everlasting life.”***¹⁷ ***“For God did not send His Son into the world to condemn the world, but that the world through Him might be saved.”*** **John 10:10** (NKJV) ***“The thief does not come except to steal, and to kill, and to destroy. I have come that they may have life, and that they may have it more abundantly.”*** **John 12:47** (NKJV) ***“And if anyone hears My words and does not believe, I do not judge him; for I did not come to judge the world but to save the world.”*** **John 18:37** (NKJV) ***“Pilate therefore said to Him, “Are You a king then?” Jesus answered, “You say rightly that I am a king. For this cause I was born, and for***

*this cause I have come into the world,
that I should bear witness to the truth.
Everyone who is of the truth hears My
voice.* 1 Timothy 1:15 (NKJV) *“This is
a faithful saying and worthy of all
acceptance, that Christ Jesus came into
the world to save sinners, of whom I am
chief.”*

- *He sells all!* He gives up everything to redeem the treasure! Luke 2:7 (NKJV) *“And she brought forth her firstborn
Son, and wrapped Him in swaddling
cloths, and laid Him in a manger,
because there was no room for them in
the inn.”* Luke 22:37 (NKJV) *“For I
say to you that this which is written
must still be accomplished in Me: ‘And
He was numbered with the
transgressors.’ For the things
concerning Me have an end.”* Acts 8:33 (NKJV) *“In His humiliation His justice
was taken away, And who will declare
His generation? For His life is taken*

from the earth.” 2 Corinthians 8:9

(NKJV) “For you know the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ, that though He was rich, yet for your sakes He became poor, that you through His poverty might become rich.” Philippians 2:7-8

(NKJV) “Made Himself of no reputation, taking the form of a bondservant, and coming in the likeness of men.” 8 And being found in appearance as a man, He humbled Himself and became obedient to the point of death, even the death of the cross.”

- He buys the treasure! He not only pays the purchase price but pays the ultimate price for the treasure! Romans 5:8
(NKJV) “But God demonstrates His own love toward us, in that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us.” 1 Corinthians 15:3-4 (NKJV) “For I delivered to you first of all that which I also received: that Christ died for our

sins according to the Scriptures,⁴ and that He was buried, and that He rose again the third day according to the Scriptures.” [2 Corinthians 5:21](#) (NKJV)

“For He made Him who knew no sin to be sin for us, that we might become the righteousness of God in Him.”

[Galatians 1:4](#) (NKJV) *“Who gave Himself for our sins, that He might deliver us from this present evil age, according to the will of our God and Father.”* [Galatians 4:4-5](#) (NKJV) *“But when the fullness of the time had come, God sent forth His Son, born of a woman, born under the law,⁵ to redeem those who were under the law, that we might receive the adoption as sons.”* [1 Peter 2:24](#) (NKJV)

“Who Himself bore our sins in His own body on the tree, that we, having died to sins, might live for righteousness—by whose stripes you were healed.” [1 Peter 3:18](#) (NKJV) *“For Christ also suffered once for sins,*

the just for the unjust, that He might bring us to God, being put to death in the flesh but made alive by the Spirit.”

- **He has great joy!** His joy is stimulated by the expectation of the day when the treasure which he has purchased will belong to Him! **Hebrews 12:2** (NKJV) *“Looking unto Jesus, the author and finisher of our faith, who for the joy that was set before Him endured the cross, despising the shame, and has sat down at the right hand of the throne of God.”* **Jude 24-25** (NKJV) *“Now to Him who is able to keep you from stumbling, And to present you faultless Before the presence of His glory with exceeding joy, 25 To God our Savior, Who alone is wise, Be glory and majesty, Dominion and power, Both now and forever.”*

2) The treasure is the Gospel of Christ.

When a man sees the truth of the Gospel of Christ he comes to the knowledge of the

treasure of salvation! When a person obtains this knowledge he does five things:

- He hides the treasure! He tucks it away in his heart so as not to lose it! This is accomplished in much the same way a running back would tuck the football away knowing that a defensive player will try to knock the ball loose.
- He goes! He makes a trip to the cross of Christ because he knows this is where true life begins.
- He sells all! He repents and turns from his former path.
- He buys the treasure! He gives all and commits all to possess the treasure.
- He has great joy! For the first time he experiences the completeness and satisfaction which the treasure brings.

Both of these two interpretations fit what is being said and I believe both interpretations to be accurate. One has a prophetic,

historical meaning and one has a spiritual meaning.

VI. THE PARABLE OF PEARLS...

Matt 13:45-46 (NKJV) *"Again, the kingdom of heaven is like a merchant seeking beautiful pearls, 46 who, when he had found one pearl of great price, went and sold all that he had and bought it."* Of all the Parables listed in Matthew 13, this one is probably the most obvious when it comes to interpretation, but there are a few things I want to highlight.

When we hear the word Pearl it doesn't really register with us what is going on because in our culture a pearl is a beautiful coveted piece of jewelry.

On the other hand, to this Jewish audience a Pearl had very little value; it was actually shocking from a Hebrew standpoint that someone would sell all he had to buy a pearl

because a Jew wouldn't walk across the street to pick up pearls if they were given away.

Pearls were greatly used in places such as Egypt as well as the ancient city of Nineveh. The Hebrews looked upon those outside their race as dogs, so what they thought did not matter.

With this in mind it must have been a tremendous shock to the Disciples as well as this Jewish audience to hear Jesus speaking of a person selling all he has to purchase a pearl.

Also, consider this, Jesus is speaking to fishermen (disciples) and they hated oysters because the oysters were responsible for tearing up their nets and they would avoid them at all cost, so to place great value on pearls was an insult to these fishermen.

In this Parable I believe the merchant man is Jesus, the oyster is the world, the many pearls he seeks are potential believers and the pearl of great price is the church.

1) The merchant man is Jesus...

Jesus came to this world to save lost humanity. Think of what He gave up to have the opportunity of redemption:

- He gave up heaven for earth... John 1:1-12 (NKJV) ***"In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God.2 He was in the beginning with God.3 All things were made through Him, and without Him nothing was made that was made.4 In Him was life, and the life was the light of men.5 And the light shines in the darkness, and the darkness did not comprehend it. 6 There was a man sent from God, whose name was John.7 This man came for a witness, to bear witness of the Light, that all through***

him might believe.⁸ He was not that Light, but was sent to bear witness of that Light.⁹ That was the true Light which gives light to every man coming into the world.¹⁰ He was in the world, and the world was made through Him, and the world did not know Him.¹¹ He came to His own, and His own did not receive Him.¹² But as many as received Him, to them He gave the right to become children of God, to those who believe in His name:”

- *He took upon Himself the restrictions of a mere mortal... Hebrews 4:14-16 (NKJV) “Seeing then that we have a great High Priest who has passed through the heavens, Jesus the Son of God, let us hold fast our confession.¹⁵ For we do not have a High Priest who cannot sympathize with our weaknesses, but was in all points tempted as we are, yet without sin.¹⁶ Let us therefore come boldly to the*

throne of grace, that we may obtain mercy and find grace to help in time of need.”

- He who knew no sin became sin for us...
2 Corinthians 5:21 (NKJV) ***“For He made Him who knew no sin to be sin for us, that we might become the righteousness of God in Him.”***

2) The pearls which the merchant man is seeking are individual believers. The pearl is the only stone that is a by-product of a living organism. I do not know of one other kind of stone which evolves from another living organism.

Look at how a pearl is produced. A pearl is born out of suffering. A spec of sand or parasite makes its way into the oyster. The oyster is a living organism and this intruder brings great pain to the oyster. To protect itself the oyster secretes a substance known as mother-of-pearl, or aragonite (nacre). This secretion surrounds the sand or parasite

and layer by slow layer the wound of intrusion becomes a valuable jewel, a pearl.

The pain involved in the development of a pearl is excruciating. The pearl is the product of an injured life. Every person born into this world is born in pain and sin. The pain of childbirth is almost unbearable but the pain inflicted by sin is completely unbearable by mere mortals.

The processes of life can be extremely painful and usually when a person comes to Christ they come as a result of some type of crisis.

Contrary to public opinion pearls aren't smooth, natural pearls are actually rough in texture; they are never the same unless created in a lab. Most pearls which are harvested in the wild are not even round they are often misshaped.

Look at the people God decided to use:

- Noah – Got drunk...
- Abraham – Had a lying problem and passed it on to his sons...
- Rahab – Was a prostitute...
- John the Baptist – Wore a camel skin leisure suit held in place by a leather girdle and ate grasshoppers and honey...
- Simon Peter – He was a loud mouth who struggled with his temper and was somewhat of a braggart...
- Peter, James and John – Three stinking fishermen who had little to no professionalism...

The merchant man knows when he finds a pearl some shaping will be needed.

3) When the merchant man found what he was looking for he gave all to purchase the pearl of great price! John 3:16 (KJV) ***“For God so loved the world, that he gave his only begotten Son, that whosoever believeth***

in him should not perish, but have everlasting life.”

Luke 19:10 (NKJV) “The Son of Man has come to seek and to save that which was lost.” Romans 5:8-10 (NKJV) “But God demonstrates His own love toward us, in that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us.⁹ Much more then, having now been justified by His blood, we shall be saved from wrath through Him.¹⁰ For if when we were enemies we were reconciled to God through the death of His Son, much more, having been reconciled, we shall be saved by His life.”

1 Peter 3:18 (NKJV) “For Christ also suffered once for sins, the just for the unjust, that He might bring us to God, being put to death in the flesh but made alive by the Spirit.”

When others only can see the intrusion of sin in our lives, Christ sees the opportunity to make a pearl. 1 Peter 2:3-6 (NKJV) “If indeed you have tasted that the Lord is

gracious. 4 Coming to Him as to a living stone, rejected indeed by men, but chosen by God and precious,5 you also, as living stones, are being built up a spiritual house, a holy priesthood, to offer up spiritual sacrifices acceptable to God through Jesus Christ.6 Therefore it is also contained in the Scripture, “Behold, I lay in Zion A chief cornerstone, elect, precious, And he who believes on Him will by no means be put to shame.”

Pearls come with some shaping needing to be done. The old song say's “*He's still working on me.*” The Hemphill's made popular a song which say's “*I'm not perfect, just forgiven, haven't yet arrived but I'm on my way. Since Jesus saved me and forgave me I can't say I'm perfect but I can say I'm saved.*”

[We are the jewels](#) God desires to place around His Royal Neck to display for the entire world to see. Jeremiah 29:11-12

(NKJV) *“For I know the thoughts that I think toward you, says the LORD, thoughts of peace and not of evil, to give you a future and a hope.”¹² Then you will call upon Me and go and pray to Me, and I will listen to you.”* Jude 24 (NKJV) *“Now to Him who is able to keep you from stumbling, And to present you faultless Before the presence of His glory with exceeding joy.”*

4) The pearl of great price is the church; the corporate body of Christ. This is the crown jewel of the merchant man. Jesus died to purchase the church. Matthew 16:13-19 (NKJV) *“When Jesus came into the region of Caesarea Philippi, He asked His disciples, saying, **“Who do men say that I, the Son of Man, am?”***¹⁴ So they said, *“Some say John the Baptist, some Elijah, and others Jeremiah or one of the prophets.”*¹⁵ He said to them, ***“But who do you say that I am?”***¹⁶ Simon Peter answered and said, *“You are the Christ, the*

*Son of the living God.”¹⁷ Jesus answered and said to him, “**Blessed are you, Simon Bar-Jonah, for flesh and blood has not revealed this to you, but My Father who is in heaven.**¹⁸ “**And I also say to you that you are Peter, and on this rock I will build My church, and the gates of Hades shall not prevail against it.”***

VII. THE PARABLE OF THE NET...

Matthew 13:47-50 (NKJV) “Again, the kingdom of heaven is like a dragnet that was cast into the sea and gathered some of every kind,⁴⁸ “which, when it was full, they drew to shore; and they sat down and gathered the good into vessels, but threw the bad away.⁴⁹ “So it will be at the end of the age. The angels will come forth, separate the wicked from among the just,⁵⁰ “and cast them into the furnace of fire. There will be wailing and gnashing of teeth.”

As we study this parable you must keep in mind the fact that **Jesus’ audience is**

composed primarily of people whose trade was fishing or some of their family members made their living in the fishing business.

The net being spoken of here is probably a drag net or seine net. This particular net was actually a large square net that was designed to be pulled through the water behind a boat. The net was weighted down so that it formed a coned-shaped formation which would entrap everything in its path.

The fishermen could tell when the net was full by the amount of labor it took to move the boat forward. When the net was full they would pull it to shore and begin the tedious process of separating the good from the bad. The good fish were then processed for market and the bad were cast away or disposed of.

Several lessons can be learned from this parable:

1) The fishermen represent the church – We are called to be fishers of men. Mark 1:16-20 (NKJV) *“And as He walked by the Sea of Galilee, He saw Simon and Andrew his brother casting a net into the sea; for they were fishermen.17 Then Jesus said to them, “Follow Me, and I will make you become fishers of men.”18 They immediately left their nets and followed Him.19 When He had gone a little farther from there, He saw James the son of Zebedee, and John his brother, who also were in the boat mending their nets. 20 And immediately He called them, and they left their father Zebedee in the boat with the hired servants, and went after Him.”*

The purpose of the church and the calling of every Christian is to be a *“Fisher of men.”* Mark 16:15 (NKJV) *“And He said to them, “Go into all the world and preach the gospel to every creature.”*

Neither the church nor individual believers are to be held responsible for the availability

of the fish or the conditions for catching fish, they are held responsible for fishing on a consistent basis. The responsibility of the church and individual Christians is to keep the nets clean and in the water.

I want to tell you a story about a group of people who fancied themselves to be fishermen:

They lived in an area that was populated with lakes, rivers, streams, and ponds. The lakes, rivers, streams, and ponds were filled with all kinds of fresh water fish, and the fish were hungry, and would bite almost any kind of bait.

Week after week, month after month, year after year, these people who called themselves fishermen held meetings and talked about their call to be fishermen. They also talked about the abundance of fish and the latest innovations and technology in fishing trends. They were careful to articulate what fishing was all about, to

defend fishing as a noble occupation, and passionately declared that fishing is always the primary task of fishermen.

*They were constantly scouring the landscape searching for new and better methods of fishing. They loved such slogans as “**Fishing is the primary task of every fisherman**”. They sponsored special meetings known as “**Fishermen’s campaigns**”. They went on nation-wide and world-wide tours to discuss and promote fishing, and to hear all the new developments and technological developments in fishing. They even had exhaustive sessions on how to present the bait to the fish, and new way’s to make the bait more attractive and alluring to the fish!*

*They built large beautiful buildings called “**Fishing headquarters**” and selected some of their best fishermen to staff it. They appealed to everyone to become fishermen.*

There was only one thing they did not do, fish, ever!!!

*In addition to organizing and holding regularly scheduled meetings, they organized a board to oversee the “**Fishing headquarters**” and to send fishermen out to other parts of the world where the fish were equally plentiful and available. The board appointed various committees and held numerous fishing meetings to talk about fishing, to defend fishing, and develop new strategies for fishing. But the overseers of the “**Fishing headquarters**”, the board, or the committees never went fishing!*

*Large expensive training centers known as “**Fishing schools**” were built for the purpose of teaching fishermen how to fish. They offered courses on the needs of fish, the nature of fish, the ancestral backgrounds of fish, the psychological makeup of fish, and how to approach and feed fish. The*

professors all had degrees in fishology, but none of them ever went fishing! After completing the course of study the graduates were given a fishing license and were sent out to fish full time. Some decided to fish locally, others moved away from their local surroundings, and still others went to distant lands to fish. They in turn trained and commissioned others to fish. Like the fishermen back home they often talked for hours on the need to fish, the current trends in fishing, and how to fish. Even though it was really their hearts desire to fish, these new fishermen became too busy to actually fish. Because they were too busy to fish they; recruited others to fish (called them recruits or disciples); furnished fishing equipment; they also taught their fishing disciples to develop good relationships with the fish, so the fish would be more receptive to other fishermen.

*After one stirring meeting on “**the necessity of fishing**” one young fellow left the meeting and actually went fishing! He reported the next day that he caught two outstanding fish! He was honored for his excellent catch, and immediately a nation-wide tour was scheduled so he could motivate others to go fishing! In order to have time for these motivational meetings he was forced to dispense with full-time fishing, and become a recreational fisherman. He became so successful on the motivational circuit that he was called upon to serve on the “**Fishermen’s general board**”, which consumed so much time that he had no time for fishing at all!*

Now it is true that many of the fishermen made personal sacrifices and tolerated all kinds of difficulties. Some lived near the water and had to bear the smell of dead and decaying fish all the time. They were even ridiculed by some who were constantly

making fun of their fisher-men clubs. What they did not realize was the reason they were being ridiculed was because they were always talking about, but never fishing! People outside fishing circles actually wondered if all this talk and no action might possibly be a waste of the fisherman's time.

Imagine how deeply they were hurt when someone suggested that those who don't fish are not actually fishermen!

This is a sad commentary on the modern day church. We have become more concerned with proper technique; making sure the nets are just right; the style of our fishing outfit; and a host of other things rather than engaging in the art of fishing. **If we are to fulfill the command of Jesus we must finally put our net back into the water.**

2) If the fishermen represent the church and individual Christians then the net represents the methods the church uses for catching

[fish](#). I believe it is the responsibility of the church to determine the most effective method of fishing.

Our message should never change but our methods must be in a constant state of change. If we are to be effective in fulfilling the Great Commission we must embrace a philosophy of Relevance without Compromise. [Relevance without Compromise means the church becomes relevant to its culture without compromising its message or morals.](#)

It has been said that people are resistant to change but I am not at all sure this is true. It is my opinion that the resistance to change is on an extremely limited basis. People do not like change in their religious patterns but they embrace it throughout the rest of their culture. Let me explain:

- No-one in this room washed their clothes this week on a rub board or used a wringer type washing machine...

- Everyone in this room uses a refrigerator rather than an ice box to keep their perishable groceries from ruining...
- None of us will go home tonight to a home whose lights consist of a coal oil lantern...
- All of us drove an air conditioned automobile to church...
- Just about everyone in this room has either a credit card or a debit card in their pocket right now...

People like change in many areas of their life but they resist it steadfastly in their religion. It is my responsibility to lead this church in keeping our methods of reaching the lost relevant enough to attract its culture. It is amazing to me that people expect a pastor to run a church as if we are still in the fifties yet they expect him to figure out how to keep it from going into a free fall. This would be like us expecting you to open an appliance store and sell nothing but rub-boards, wringer type washing machines and

clotheslines, yet our expectations are for you to make this a fortune 500 company! We would be setting you up for failure and the church has done just that, set itself up for failure by its resistance to change.

If we are to make a living in the fishing business we cannot do it with a worm on a hook, we must seek a much more innovative way of catching fish. **The church must always be on the lookout for new and improved ways of attracting the lost.** (Story of a man who claimed to have pet fish)

3) Remember, the fishermen are the church and individual believers. The dragnet is our methods of reaching the lost. The dragnet cannot distinguish between the good and the bad. The net captures everything in its path.

If you fish with a single hook you can bait it for certain kinds of fish and you can be somewhat selective in what kind of fish you are going after.

When you pull a net behind a boat you get everything within the path of the net; the

good and the bad; the large and the small; the edible and the poisonous; the marketable and the unmarketable.

The separation of the fish, sorting the good and the bad represents the end of the world and the final judgment. It is not the

responsibility of the fishermen to determine what is in the net, they have a responsibility to make sure the nets are in good condition, drag it through the water and get it to the shore so the separation process can begin.

We should not allow ourselves to get bent out of shape when we think someone is getting by with something they should be called into question about, trust me the sorting day is coming! When you drag a net, you will get a little bit of everything in it. Even Noah's boat had a couple of skunks on it!

Remember when we talked about the wheat and the tares? The same thing is going on here; the good will eventually be sorted from the bad.

It is not the responsibility of individual believers to decide who is bad and who is good. This is a responsibility reserved for God and His angels. If man attempts to undertake this responsibility he will ultimately err in choosing who is bad and who is good because he is not omniscient. Even if man could rightly judge for a short period of time, eventually his pride would cause his judgment to be in error. Look at the difference which will be made between the good and the bad at the end of the age:

The good:

- Matthew 25:31-34 (NKJV) ***“When the Son of Man comes in His glory, and all the holy angels with Him, then He will sit on the throne of His glory.³² “All the nations will be gathered before Him, and He will separate them one from another, as a shepherd divides his sheep from the goats.³³ “And He will set the sheep on His right hand, but the***

goats on the left.³⁴ “Then the King will say to those on His right hand, ‘Come, you blessed of My Father, inherit the kingdom prepared for you from the foundation of the world:”

- Colossians 3:4 (NKJV) *“When Christ who is our life appears, then you also will appear with Him in glory.”*

The bad:

- Matthew 13:49-50 (NKJV) *“So it will be at the end of the age. The angels will come forth, separate the wicked from among the just,⁵⁰ “and cast them into the furnace of fire. There will be wailing and gnashing of teeth.”*
- Luke 12:2-5 (NKJV) *“There is nothing covered that will not be revealed, nor hidden that will not be known.³ “Therefore whatever you have spoken in the dark will be heard in the light, and what you have spoken in the ear in inner rooms will be proclaimed on the housetops. ⁴ “And I say to you, My*

friends, do not be afraid of those who kill the body, and after that have no more that they can do.⁵ “But I will show you whom you should fear: Fear Him who, after He has killed, has power to cast into hell; yes, I say to you, fear Him!”

VIII. THE PARABLE OF THE HOUSEHOLDER...

In this parable Jesus is attempting to explain to His disciples that they possess the same abilities and privileges the scribes and householders possessed. Scribes and householders were unusually blessed. Let's look at the two.

The Jewish Scribe:

- Possessed two unusual traits; they were extremely devoted and were able to commit all their time to the study of their religion.

The Householder:

- Was the head of a house and possessed all the treasures of the estate including

its food and the food supply. The householder had two primary duties with regard to food; he was to store the old food in a manner which kept it fresh for as long as possible and he was to add the new food to the old, serving each at the appropriate time.

Why would Jesus speak to His disciples in a way that references a scribe and householder in the same breath? What did this mean to the disciples and more importantly what does this mean to us?

With regard to the scribes:

- Christ wanted His disciples to develop the same devotion as a scribe, but direct it toward the Kingdom of Heaven...

Romans 12:1-2 (KJV) ***"I beseech you therefore, brethren, by the mercies of God, that ye present your bodies a living sacrifice, holy, acceptable unto God, which is your reasonable service. 2 And be not conformed to this world: but be ye transformed by the renewing***

of your mind, that ye may prove what is that good, and acceptable, and perfect, will of God.” Galatians 2:20 (KJV) “I am crucified with Christ: nevertheless I live; yet not I, but Christ liveth in me: and the life which I now live in the flesh I live by the faith of the Son of God, who loved me, and gave himself for me.” Matthew 22:37 (NKJV) “Jesus said to him, “‘You shall love the LORD your God with all your heart, with all your soul, and with all your mind.’” As followers of Christ we are to follow Him with the same kind of devotion.

- The scribe spent the bulk of his time studying religion. Jesus wanted to divert the disciple’s attention from this present age to the Kingdom of Heaven... 2 Timothy 2:15 (NKJV) “*Be diligent to present yourself approved to God, a worker who does not need to be ashamed, rightly dividing the word of truth.*”

- The scribe spent his time searching the truths of the Old Testament but Jesus wanted the disciples to focus on both the Old and the New Testaments... In an attempt to walk in a way which pleases Jesus we must devote ourselves to study the whole counsel of God. 2 Timothy 3:16 (NKJV) ***All Scripture is given by inspiration of God, and is profitable for doctrine, for reproof, for correction, for instruction in righteousness. 17 that the man of God may be complete, thoroughly equipped for every good work.***

With regard to a householder:

- The householder was responsible to share his resources with his family, employees and friends... Matthew 28:19-20 (NKJV) ***Go therefore and make disciples of all the nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit,*** 20 ***teaching them to observe all***

things that I have commanded you; and lo, I am with you always, even to the end of the age.” Amen.” Luke 19:10

(NKJV) *“For the Son of Man has come to seek and to save that which was lost.”* John 20:21 (NKJV) *“So Jesus said to them again, **“Peace to you! As the Father has sent Me, I also send you.”**”*

- The householder was to share his revelation, both old and new... John 1:17-18 (NKJV) *“For the law was given through Moses, but grace and truth came through Jesus Christ.18 No one has seen God at any time. The only begotten Son, who is in the bosom of the Father, He has declared Him.”*
- The householder was to share his truth, both old and new... John 14:6 (NKJV) *“Jesus said to him, **“I am the way, the truth, and the life. No one comes to the Father except through Me.”**”*

- The householder was to share information, both old and new...
Matthew 5:17 (NKJV) ***“Do not think that I came to destroy the Law or the Prophets. I did not come to destroy but to fulfill.”*** Romans 8:3 (NKJV) ***“For what the law could not do in that it was weak through the flesh, God did by sending His own Son in the likeness of sinful flesh, on account of sin: He condemned sin in the flesh.”*** Hebrews 8:6 (NKJV) ***“But now He has obtained a more excellent ministry, inasmuch as He is also Mediator of a better covenant, which was established on better promises.”*** Hebrews 9:14-15 (NKJV) ***“How much more shall the blood of Christ, who through the eternal Spirit offered Himself without spot to God, cleanse your conscience from dead works to serve the living God?15 And for this reason He is the Mediator of the new covenant, by***

means of death, for the redemption of the transgressions under the first covenant, that those who are called may receive the promise of the eternal inheritance.”

Heritage is not bad unless it is viewed as a permanent destination. The godly past is not to be discarded, it is to be developed, built upon, fulfilled, and made better. Philippians 3:13-14 (NKJV) “*Brethren, I do not count myself to have apprehended; but one thing I do, forgetting those things which are behind and reaching forward to those things which are ahead. 14 I press toward the goal for the prize of the upward call of God in Christ Jesus.*”